

Suggestions from Reviewer 1 (accept with revisions)

This is a study of the early-20th-century American folk song "Stackolee". (At least, I think one would call it a folk song; as far as I can tell, the author never identifies the musical style(s) that the paper is dealing with.) The many recorded versions of "Stackolee" vary widely in melody, harmonic progression, and phrase structure. They mostly seem to gravitate towards existing "schemes" found in other songs: either twelve-bar schemes associated with the songs "Frankie and Johnny" and "Railroad Bill" (those two songs represent different schemes, with different harmonic progressions) or an eight-bar scheme associated with "How Long". The paper shows how versions of "Stackolee" employ these schemes, in some cases even borrowing lyrics from associated songs.

On the whole this is an excellent paper. The topic is interesting and the argument convincing. I haven't seen a lot of work in this area in music theory (though I'm not an expert on it). The paper is well-written and the ideas are clearly presented. The musical examples are also nice (I checked the accuracy of a few of them against recordings) and the discussion coordinates with them closely, that is, I didn't find any inconsistencies between the discussion and the examples.

I think the paper is acceptable as is. I have a few thoughts below but I would leave them to the discretion of the author. In what follows I address the author directly.

The issue of syllabic stress arises repeatedly: you define an "accent" as "the combination of a stressed syllable with a metrically strong downbeat position" (p. 10) and then invoke this concept on several occasions, e.g. when you say that Ex. 8a has seven accents and Ex. 8b has ten (p. 13). On the whole your labeling of accents (stressed syllables) seems good to me. It might be worth stating the usual criteria (which you generally follow): each "content word" (noun, verb, or adjective) generally has a least one stressed syllable, while monosyllabic "function words" (prepositions, pronouns, determiners, other categories) usually carry no stress (though occasionally they do). It's hard to find an authoritative statement of this that doesn't use a lot of jargon, but here's one: Bruce Hayes, *Metrical Stress Theory* (U Chicago Press, 1995), p. 24 (viewable on Google books). There is some subjectivity here, both in deciding what's a content word vs. a function word (adverbs are problematic) and deciding whether a word is stressed. E.g. in Ex. 8b, you say "Some" in m. 6 is an accent (and therefore stressed); I think most would consider this a function word (a quantifier) but it could be considered stressed in this case; there's a tendency, even in speech, to shift stresses to create an alternation of stressed and unstressed syllables (see e.g. Hayes pp. 27-30). You may not need to say all this but it's good to be aware of it.

Many thanks for telling me about this great source, Hayes—I bought a copy. It's difficult to include a detailed discussion of Hayes, but I did include a citation and a relevant quote in note 5.

I do have one change to suggest, though I don't think it's essential: I think the paper would be more successful if it could be shown to have more general significance beyond the particular songs discussed. By "more successful" I mean in particular that I think it would be more widely read (which is presumably desirable!). When I say "general significance", I mean, at least, general significance to the style of music under consideration (as noted in my first paragraph, you never even say what that style is!). You don't have to give a lot of examples but you could at least claim (if you think it's true) that this kind of schematic process occurs widely in the style. You sort of hint at such a general claim at the end of the article but it would be good to make it at the beginning of the article as well. (The current opening of the article is enticing in a way – it would be great "lead" for a non-specialist audience, but I'm not sure it's the best way to draw in the readers of Theory & Practice.)

Page 2 now clarifies style and genre, and on pages 2–3 I mention how widespread and productive these patterns were in early blues and country music. I also rewrote the last paragraph of the opening section to make the general claim of the article more clearly closer to the beginning.

Note 2 also mentions that the schemes form part of a stock repertory, which further suggests something of the topic's general significance, and the new note 3 cites Michael Taft, Bertrand Bronson, David Evans, and Malcolm Laws for other sources that discuss the intersection of lyrics and form. I also cite several sources (Blum, Stoia, van der Merwe) that discuss the ubiquity of schemes in popular music.

I certainly take your point about the scope of the article, but this closer focus is intentional and why I sent the article to Theory and Practice, which requests shorter-format works and analytical vignettes. The article is one close case study of the intersection of lyrics and form.

Small points:

p. 12: "Example. 8[b]" - should be Ex.

I changed it to "Example 8[b]" without the period, to match the rest of the article.

You claim that "Stackolee" is sometimes set with "Stack" on the strong beat: e.g. Ex. 12a, Mississippi John Hurt's performance. (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KWM82eQKdQk>) That seems very odd to me. It does indeed occur; I notice, though, that it sometimes causes the meter to shift. E.g. around 1:10 we have this:

[2/2] bad man | oh cruel | [3/2] Stackolee | [2/2] ^2 ^3 ^1 (guitar riff) | |

Maybe he reinterpreted "-lee" as a downbeat as he was singing it. (I also feel that the 5-4-2-3-1 melodic gesture is most naturally placed with the 5 and 1 on strong beats.)

I'm interested that you hear it that way. I attribute the malleability in meter more to its position in the twelve-bar framework than to the lyrics or melody—the most common place to find elongated or abbreviated bars is in that space between the end of one verse and the beginning of another. I also hear the harmonic shift, along with the meter established previously in the verse, signaling a downbeat coinciding with “Stack” in Hurt’s version.

In Guthrie's rendition (Ex. 12b): You claim that his expansion "puts 'mean' in a weaker hypermetric position than either 'bad' or '-lee'", but even your unexpanded version (Ex. 12c) does this, does it not?

You're right, of course, I could make this description clearer. I changed it to “As shown in an interpretation on a higher hypermetric level (Ex. 12[d]), Guthrie’s expansion puts both ‘bad’ and ‘-lee’ on hypermetric downbeats, leaving the intervening hypermetric downbeat unaccented.” I’ve also rewritten the end of the paragraph to be more concise.

I wonder why you choose to notate the songs in 2/2: that is, you assume two tactus beats per measure. My inclination would be to make the measures twice as long, so that they have four tactus beats per measure. (The schemes would then be six-bar and four-bar schemes.) The twelve-bar blues scheme generally has four tactus beats per measure, doesn't it? (Or perhaps I'm wrong.) By calling "Frankie and Johnny" a "twelve-bar scheme" you may be making it seem more similar to the blues scheme than it actually is.

I have no trouble hearing two-beat bars where I’ve transcribed them, but I certainly understand that some readers would transcribe the songs differently. In a certain sense, the idea of any written bars—whether in 2/2 or 4/4 or another time signature—is artificially imposed, since so much of this music disseminated through oral and aural transmission, including through recordings, without any notated source. That’s one reason I like to rely so

much on “metric positions,” because that method allows for easier comparative analysis of songs that are clearly related without letting the number of “bars” get in the way.

One of the most widely accepted explanations for the origins of the twelve-bar blues is that its twelve-bar profile emerged directly from “Franky and Johnny” and other blues ballads that predate it (Paul Oliver, David Evans, Peter C. Muir, and others make this argument), so it’s fitting to describe them all as twelve-bar schemes. “Frankie” is almost universally depicted and described as a twelve-bar form, and the earliest printings of the song and others like it (e.g. the “Bill Bailey” songs by Hughie Cannon) have twelve bars, many written in duple meter and many others written in quadruple meter. I would say the standard twelve-bar blues shows the same flexibility with regard to meter—that it can be realized in either duple or quadruple meter.

Suggestions from Reviewer 2 (revise and resubmit)

This article argues that the murder ballad “Stackolee,” which emerged in popular song in the early 1900s, is notable because, unlike other ballad topics, it is paired with several different country and blues schemas: the 12-bar “Frankie and Johnnie” and “Railroad Bill,” and the 8-bar “How Long.” The article examines three categories of versions of “Stackolee,” based on which schema they use, and finds that specific images and lyrical phrases recur in each. These observations suggests that blues musicians conceived of the schemas not only as a melodic and harmonic pattern but also as a set of associated lyrics and images.

I suggest that the author revise and resubmit this article. The article has many virtues: it makes a clear claim at the end; it is thorough in its citation of other scholarship; it selects excellent examples; and for the most part, it presents its ideas with admirable clarity. Moreover, its length is appropriate to the topic: it explores a single song topic in a short, focused essay.

That said, the author’s primary claim, as far as I ascertain, does not become clear until the final few paragraphs. When the article attempts to discuss its primary intervention earlier in the article, its language becomes abstruse or vague. The article would be stronger if it presented its main argument more clearly at the beginning, and if it explained the broader “so what” of its findings. What do the different ballad versions tell us about the nature of song schemas, or about the different versions’ expressive functions, or about early blues and country music? Are there other scholars who have written on either the role of text in musical schemas or this ballad? Are there other “floating” or “promiscuous” song texts? Addressing some or all of these questions would help better persuade readers of the significance of the author’s analyses.

I agree that I could make the main argument more clearly at the beginning, which I've done now at the end of the opening section. I discuss these changes in more detail below in the responses to the reader's comments on individual sections. I've also added a note (the new note 3) citing Michael Taft, Bertrand Bronson, David Evans, and Malcolm Laws for other sources that discuss the intersection of lyrics and form. The other "floating" or "promiscuous" song text I mention by way of comparison is "Barbara Allen" and Seeger's study of the ballad.

I take the reader's point about the scope of the article—the question of the broader "so what"—but this closer focus is intentional and why I sent the article to Theory and Practice, which requests shorter-format works and analytical vignettes. The article is one close case study of the intersection of lyrics and form. But page 2 now includes a line about the ubiquity of schemes in early blues and country music, and note 2 mentions that these patterns form part of a stock repertory. The article also cites several sources (Blum, Stoia, van der Merwe) that discuss other schemes in detail.

Some of the schemas discussed were not relevant to the article's primary argument and could be cut. In addition, there are a passages where the article repeats information and presents its information in an order that is difficult to follow, especially pages 5–10. These sections should be rewritten for concision and clarity.

The short discussion of other patterns situates the schemes that combine with "Stackolee"—those most relevant to the primary argument—within early blues and country music more broadly, and briefly show where the ballad appears within the larger formal landscape of the repertoire. The new order of presentation and the more minimal discussion of the other schemes should make the essay less confusing and avoid distraction from the main points.

Here are a few comments on individual sections in the article:

p. 2. The sentence "This study will focus on the ballad's musical attributes and its combination with multiple formal patterns" is vague and can be cut.

I cut the part about the "combination with multiple formal patterns." But the rest of the sentence specifies how this analytical article differs in its approach to "Stackolee" from the historical studies just mentioned. It now appears as the opening of a new sentence that also clarifies the repertoire explored.

p. 3: In the third paragraph, the author makes, as far as I can tell, their primary claim: “The ballad’s combination with different schemes demonstrates two different processes of lyrical development. Its association with the “Frankie” scheme shows how a musical pattern can be a vehicle for lyrical crosspollination...” etc. This language is abstruse at points and vague at others. “Two processes of lyrical development” is a very broad and generalized phrase, for example, as is “means of lyrical divergence” later in the paragraph---divergence from what? If the answer is “lyrics in other versions,” why not just say “tend to use a different set of lyrics”? The “crosspollination” reference is confusing.

I suggest that the author rewrite this paragraph using more direct language and more clearly explaining the motivation for examining different versions of the ballad.

“Two processes of lyrical development” is a broad phrase, but the rest of the rewritten paragraph should now clarify it. “Lyrical crosspollination” is now more clearly defined by the sentence that follows: “lyrics easily migrate between ‘Frankie and Johnny’ and ‘Stackolee’ because the ballads share the same scheme.” I agree that the concept of lyrical divergence needs clarification. I changed the end of the first section to read: “Conversely, its combination with the ‘How Long’ scheme shows how a ballad’s association with a different musical pattern can give rise to a different branch of the song, with its own distinct lyrics and themes: different lyrical content consistently appears in versions of ‘Stackolee’ that combine with the “How Long” scheme, because musicians associate certain parts of the ‘Stackolee’ myth only with the eight-bar pattern.” These changes should address the reader’s concern above about making the main argument of the article more clearly and earlier on.

p. 6–7: The article talks about the AB couplet versions of Stackolee in the middle of talking about first 12-bar ballad forms and then 12-bar ballad schemas. The organization feels confusing to me. In addition, the author discusses rhythm and accents on pages 5–6, and then again states on page 7 that the difference schemas are defined by “details of their rhythmic profiles.”

I reorganized the order of presentation. The article now discusses the eight-bar AB form after discussing twelve-bar ballad schemas.

The first discussion of rhythm and accents that the reader mentions (formerly on pages 5–6, now on page 6) demonstrates the similarities between the ballads, the rhythmic attributes that make them all ballad meter. The second discussion (on page 7) demonstrates their differences, the rhythmic details that make them different schemas. This second instance that the reader points to is part of the “roadmap” for the section on “Ballad Schemas,” which first discusses harmonic progression, then melodic designs, then details of the rhythmic profiles.

6: What type of accent does the author mean by “no accent in position 4.” Stressed syllable? An accented note in the voice part with a chord change?

I changed it to “stressed syllable.”

p. 7: The text “In addition to their divergent texts, the differences...” repeats some information from p. 5. Make sure that unnecessary repetitions are cut.

I made a real effort, but I really can’t find the repetition of information. Page 5 (now p. 6 in the new version) discusses the similarities in poetic form and rhythmic profile between “Frankie and Johnnie” and “Railroad Bill,” whereas page 7 discusses the differences in their texts and in the details of their rhythmic profiles. These topics are opposed, not redundant. If the reader makes it clear where the unnecessary repetition is I will go through it again.

pages 7–8: The discussion of the rhythmic profiles of each schema is clear, but the author should acknowledge at this point in the article that some flexibility in bar length is common—indeed, some of the examples have this type of flexibility (Examples 4b and 10b).

I included the observation about rhythmic flexibility later, in note 9, in the discussion of the former Example 4(b), now Example 3(b).

p. 9: The passage “Naturally, the ‘Frankie’ tune often combines with lyrics...but singers associate it with other ballad topic...” repeats information already given before.

Again, I’m unsure where the repetition is. This is the first discussion of the “Frankie” tune, and I haven’t yet said which topics this tune combines with. Is the reader thinking of the earlier discussion (now on page 7) of the combination of the “Frankie” scheme with various ballad texts, including “Frankie,” “Boll Weevil,” and “Delia”? That discussion says nothing about melodic design or which tunes combine with which ballad texts.

p. 10: The phrase “The accent patterns in these refrains are in turn closely intertwined with harmonic rhythm...” is overly abstract and vague. I suggest simplifying to something like “In each schema, the downbeat accents coincide with a chord change.”

I think that the original wording better conveys the correlation between accent pattern and harmonic rhythm. The reader’s suggested revision makes the correlation sound more like a coincidence than a defining attribute.

p. 10: The author discusses the two “downbeat accents” in the “Frankie schema,” but as far as I can tell, the author already discussed this issue on pages 5–6. Is this information a repetition, or is the author trying to make some subtle point here? The article would be much easier to follow if the rhythmic features of the 12-bar schemas were defined clearly once and once only.

The reorganization of the article, in which twelve-bar ballad meter and twelve-bar schemes are discussed adjacently, should, I hope, make the presentation easier to follow. The earlier passage the reader refers to (formerly on pages 5–6, now on page 6) explains ballad meter, which is a broader category of poetic form and phrase rhythm common to all the twelve-bar forms. That passage doesn’t discuss the number of downbeat accents in the refrain. The later passage (page 10) discusses the attributes that make the twelve-bar patterns different schemes, which include the number of accents in their refrains.

Pp. 10–11: Since the AB versions of “Stackolee” primarily use the “How Long” schema (p. 16), and the later sections in the article only discuss instances of this interaction, it is not clear to me why it is necessary to discuss the “Trouble in Mind” and “Key to the Highway” schemas. The discussion of these schemas is a distraction from the article’s main point. Why not simply say something like, “There are several 8-bar blues schemas in AB form, the one that is most often paired with “Stackolee” is called the “How Long” schema and will be defined below.” The author could then proceed to immediately discussing this scheme.

The reason for the short discussion of the “Trouble in Mind” and “Key to the Highway” schemes is to briefly contextualize the “How Long” scheme—the same way I contextualized “Frankie” and “Railroad Bill” in the broader category of ballad meter—and to explain that, whereas the others have been readily defined, the parameters of the “How Long” scheme are more elusive. But I agree that I need to make the relevance of the other schemes clearer and not to let them distract from the main discussion, so I rewrote the section to minimize discussion of the other schemes and to emphasize the elusiveness of the “How Long” scheme.

p. 11: The claim that the “How Long” scheme has “the pattern whose parameters are hardest to specify” strikes me as an overstatement, since the author does precisely that in the following passage. Moreover, the “Railroad Bill” scheme also has multiple possibilities for realization (fewer than “How Long,” I grant), and the author summarized them without difficulty earlier. I suggest reframing this discussion and summarizing the discussion more efficiently.

Demonstrating the relative elusiveness of the “How Long” scheme is another reason it’s useful to mention the other eight-bar schemes—in comparison to the “Trouble in Mind” and “Key to the Highway” schemes, the musical parameters of the “How Long” scheme are much more difficult to pin down. I agree that the article defines the parameters of the scheme, but this definition also demonstrates the scheme’s malleability and ambiguity.

I describe the “Railroad Bill” scheme as “doubly predetermined” in harmony and melody, meaning it is among the least variable schemes discussed here—less so than “Frankie and Johnnie” and much less so than the “How Long” scheme. I think that Example 9—with its parentheses, question marks, and frequent absence of boldface type in the harmony—conveys the relative flexibility of the “How Long” scheme in comparison to the much more definite and fixed abstraction in Example 4(c) (formerly 5[c]).

p. 11: I suggest adding example citations in this sentence: “To take just one instance of melodic divergence, Carr’s octave descent in bars 3–4 expands the melody into the lower register (Ex. 8[a]), whereas Glaze’s expands it into the upper register (Ex. 8[b]).”

I added the example citations.

p. 12: “If the descending $\wedge 8-b\wedge 7$ gesture is absent from the vocal part, it appears in the accompaniment”...Does it appear always or often?

In all of the examples given, it appears in either one or the other.

p.12: Delete the period after “Example” in “Example. 8[b]”

I deleted the period.

p.13: I suggest deleting “, as we’ll see in the following section”.

I prefer to keep it, because otherwise it will seem strange that I’m not offering an example here that doesn’t use the closing I–V–I progression.

p.14: I suggest rephrasing this end of the first paragraph for concision: “Ma Rainey’s “Stack O’Lee Blues” (Ex. 10[a]), for instance, combines the “Stackolee” lyrics with both the harmonic

progression and melodic outline of the “Frankie” scheme. Other combinations use only the harmonic progression and substitute a new tune, as in Woody Guthrie’s “Stackolee” (Ex. 10[b]).” I suggest avoiding the word “idiosyncratic,” which can be interpreted as pejorative.

I agree these lines could be more concise, so I rephrased them, but a bit differently than suggested. It’s an attribute of the “Frankie” scheme that it carries multiple tunes, whereas the harmonic progression is a defining characteristic, so I don’t want to refer to “both the harmonic progression and melodic outline of the ‘Frankie’ scheme,” which suggests that they’re equally consistent.

p.14: Cut the phrase “observing the melody’s narrower range for variation,” since this is redundant. The author already said that the scheme is doubly predetermined by harmony and melody.

I cut the phrase.

p.15: The hypothetical version of Guthrie’s “Stackolee” strikes me as irrelevant and can be cut. The main point about his version seems to be that his metric expansion allows him to maintain the accent structure by placing two accents on hypermetric downbeats. The last two sentences repeat information already given and can be cut. I think footnote 11 can also be deleted, since “augmentation” is a commonly discussed in many textbooks, not just Caplin, and it is odd to reference Caplin in an article that is otherwise about country and blues.

The hypothetical version of Guthrie’s refrain is relevant because it shows what the refrain would be like, and how it would fail to achieve the rhythmic-harmonic interplay of either twelve-bar scheme, if he hadn’t expanded it—i.e., it shows the reason for the expansion.

I’ve rewritten the end of the paragraph to be more concise.

The Caplin quote is directly applicable to the passage in question, and scholars of popular music cite Caplin with some frequency. I also cite Schachter and Gjerdingen, who likewise work with much different repertoire, so I don’t think the reference seems too out of place.

P.17: Delete “Finally.” Rephrase “remarkable process of textual exchange and divergence” to make a more specific claim and explain the motivation for examining the different versions.

I took out “Finally.” I changed the rest of the sentence to be more specific, and to better prepare the rest of the paragraph, which explains the two different processes of lyrical development.

The discussion from pages 17–23 is quite clear and interesting.

Thanks.

P. 24: The conclusion is underwritten and needs a little more explanation of the significance of the study.

I expanded the conclusion.